Høgskolen i Østfold

Qualitative Research, Data Sharing, and Ethical Engagement in the Age of Big Data

Kristian Sandbekk Norsted | Library

Ethical Considerations

- Excessive protection can exclude vital perspectives from research findings.
- It’s important to assess risks thoroughly instead of avoiding action due to potential harm.
- Ethical engagement involves accepting and managing risks to achieve positive outcomes.

Big Data and Value

- Big tech uses big data to understand and shape user desires and behavior
- Everybody's online actions create hidden data ("shadow text") exploited for profit
- Data-driven manipulation shifts power to big tech, thus threatening autonomy and democracy

"Surveillance capitalists know everything about us, whereas their operations are designed to be unknowable *to us*. They accumulate vast domains of new knowledge *from us*, but not *for us*" — Shoshana Zuboff

Universities and the Public Good

"Knowledge enlightens only if the advantage enjoyed by its original creators is removed through mass dissemination" — Steve Fuller

- Restricting research data mirrors big tech's self-serving data practices and undermines the idea of knowledge as a public good
- A public good enriches society beyond profit, and universities support truth-seeking through open inquiry
- Sharing data is ethically affirmative as it bolsters researchers and their institutions as manufacturers of knowledge as a public good

Suggested Reading List

- Arendt, H. (2006 [1963]). *Eichmann in Jerusalem: A report on the banality of evil*. Penguin Books.
- Fuller, S. (2023). *Back to the university's future: The second coming of Humboldt*. Springer.
- Kulick, D., & Rydström, J. (2015). *Loneliness and its opposite: Sex, disability, and the ethics of engagement*. Duke University Press.
- Zuboff, S. (2019). *The age of surveillance capitalism: The fight for a human future at the new frontier of power*. Profile Books.
- Varoufakis, Y. (2023). *Technofeudalism: What killed capitalism*. Vintage.